

Shagor Rahman: "Humanity's Story: A Search for Moral Clarity"

50:46

the next recorded talk is 50 minutes

long By shager Ramen Humanity story a

search for moral

Clarity hi

everybody so I'll be going over what I'm

calling Humanity's story a search for

moral Clarity and I'll get into kind of

what that cheeky title means um going

over kind of myth morality narrative

self- understanding and um the meaning

of life and no that one was too far but

I guess not not too much farther than

one I'm claiming um so yeah before we

get started I just want to give a big

thank you to the active inference

Institute um you know for overall the

work they do um it's been super

rewarding um and engaging to to be a

part of uh I put my information here so

feel free to reach out if anything picks

your interest or you know bothers you or

you have to correct anything feel free

to um give me a

shout so we'll be discussing um you know

a few things as I mentioned so one of

the big roles um that I feel active

inference can um you know one of the

ways that I can at least intuitively

scale

into human culture now first of all

through our use of symbols kind of what

makes us unique as a species um can be

understood semiotically or through

symbols um and the road there uh as I

make the case in myth of objectivity is

through morality um largely through
bodifying norms and expectations which
again ties very nicely into Act of
inference I believe the last way is to
narrative and specifically I'll be
talking about uh kind of at a meta level
The Narrative of modern narrative and
and you know why are we why are we doing
this you know it's you know epistemic
reasons interesting as it is but also I
think that kind of applying a r rigorous
framework to humanity specifically
particularly as we get into narrative um
we'll see it more broadly tackle um some
other areas of
humanity um this is necessary I feel for
cultural cohesion um something generally
lacking these days um you know with
partisan um and in
polarizing um the nature of our culture
at the moment and in our politics uh and
so it'll achieve hopefully or at least
understand the outlines for cultural
cohesion uh and things like social and
personal uh
integration and I'll do this by as I
mentioned by expanding upon my myth of
objectivity hypothesis right and so my
own road to to um becoming interested in
the free energy principle and active
inference was being disillusioned with
with the economics Paradigm um finding
it to be as as I'm sure other folks were
um insufficient to describing human
behavior even through the kind of quote
unquote narrow lens of the marketplace
conceiving people as a neoclassical
framework does as

utility maximizing um individual agents
who are well-versed in what their own
preferences and interests are um you
know it's kind of quite
unrealistic to say the least not only
that but behavioral economics didn't
really um do it for me either um it also
held up this idea this neoclassical idea
of rationality um as the kind of goal
standard and you can see that with some
of the recommendations you know the way
we should
um you know default constantly default a
401ks um you know maybe that makes sense
but it does it comes up with that advice
it justifies the device using this kind
of principle of stationarity meaning an
agent's um preferences should not change
over their lifetime which of course is
not not
realistic and so of speaking of um know
behavioral paradigms that are lacking um
you know at first I thought well the
neoclassical model on its own isn't
interesting um maybe we can marry that
with you know some views of moral
philosophy because I'm sure moral
philosophers have you know a much better
view of of
humanity that's what I thought uh so
here are a few uh few different moral
philosophies that maybe some of you
folks are aware of maybe others not um
but kind of briefly um deontology
utilitarianism are you know traditional
from the enlightenment era going back to
Kant um and Stuart
Mill um paradigms of moral philosophy um

interpretivism is a bit more recent but
um I think still been around for for
quite uh some time um and the last one
is uh just a couple examples of some
Eastern

philosophy and so when we think about I
guess the question I'll pose to you know
those listening is what type of Thermo
Dynamic systems in terms of um their
adaptability um you know how do we
characterize these various different
systems you know are they single
equilibria are they steady States um are
they uh maybe chaotic maybe they don't
reach any equilibria um you know how do
we think about these um so firstly
deontology uh and utilitarianism um and
you know if not familiar with them um
don't worry I'll come explain it but um
the ontology and utilitarianism um I view
as single Lake RBM even though they are
uh different um they seem to have one um
kind of one unifying mistake which is
you know the environment or kind of
context doesn't change or in other words
there is no uncertainty in these systems
that they assume you know by their
prescriptions of morality and moral
philosophy so deontology assumes there
are certain set of rules that you should
never violate that um never change over
time um so you maybe thou shall not kill
th shall not steal etc etc um there's no
conditions under which those should be
violated um and
utilitarianism this is all of your
actions are based their morality at
least is um evaluated based upon the

impact that they'll have on the the
aggregate welfare of others right so um
this is kind of featured for instance in
uh the good place for those um watched
it but the problem with both of these is
that um you know in a word it's
uncertainty right there's no epistemic
foraging there's no
model for how Agents come to learn okay
what are the rules um maybe the deontic
rules that I should follow what are the
ways that my actions impact others like
what is that process of um socialization
that kind of awareness those you know
the empathy um you know all the things
that you know you know should I read a
book should I read fiction um you know
how should I speak to people um you know
all these are essentially epistemic
tasks um of learning tasks that are not
featured into you know these twin
systems um and and I'll get into perhaps
what this reveals about Western Society
um of spoiler but this is the kind of
analytical bias of Western Society I
think revealing itself in deontology and
and utilitarianism specifically so
interpretivism um this comes out of
postmodernism I believe or at least it
was um rebr into
the dialogue following modernism into
postmodernism Etc so it says essentially
kind of rejecting these uh analytical
reduction single equilibrium as I
presented it here um you know frames of
moral philosophy and says that well it's
based on the agents interpretation of
their behavior you know what are the

context for their actions also how do they interpret their actions etc etc well of course it's an important element of morality um the kind of classification that at least I would label is chaotic right so if we're just saying it's up to someone's interpretation well how should they interpret it um should everyone interpret it differently is everyone's interpretation equally accurate how should we you know yada yada the point is that it's not super helpful for society to um as a approach to morality all right so final two confusion is and Daoism um

uh I see them as being adaptive and being steady state um focus on the kind of rituals and behaviors not content specifically not focus on particular deontics um and not kind of hyperfocused on the impacts of behaviors to others AI that that can be a component as can you know interpretation but um it's really about the emphasis of these two paradigms um kind of inherently acknowledging um that the world is changing that Society is changing and yet the goal of um morality at both personal and social level um is to find coherence so it's kind of still privileging um some kind of equilibria um some kind of Harmony but not kind of how you get there and I'll get into how it it does that um with active inference so you know active inference what I would say is

that of Daoism and um Confucianism they come from a tradition that um Carl Yung would label as a the mytholog mythological construct of the cosmic human or Cosmic man um aka the symbolic self which is the you know term I'll use for kind of going forward because it kind of ties into um you know my theme of symbolic agents Etc so the point is that uh you know Carl after serving um doing a cross-cultural analysis of various different mythologies and and traditions found that this particular what he called Arch type reemerged uh and essentially the cosmic human was the perspective that we all kind of part we all kind of connected to one another um not only to other people but to the cosmos into the world um in general and our actions do have consequences because of that inherent interconnections um moreover we do have a certain responsibility to you know the world as a whole to other people um because of our place as a kind of a node in this hierarchy this I'm signaling where I'm going with this um but it allows as you can see um an area both for the kind of characteristic uh States so the ways to minimize uncertainty kind of using both that you know epistemic and exploitative um you know Paradigm of active inference um but kind of does so specifically um by conceiving this kind of broad view of the self right and so here of course is how it connects to active inference so active

inference unlike the neoclassical
framework and unlike other
um single equilibrium um approaches to
social science and to science in general
it allows um nodes to communicate um both
with spatially and temporally and so
kind of overtime an individual um passes
information to itself or to kind of
quote unquote its its future self and um
in some ways it's its path self in
terms of goals um but the self is not a
stationary construct it is something
that is constantly seeking um who what
other nodes are kind of included in my
hierarchy um what other are including
kind of myself um and these symbolic
self is an example of our ability to
exate all these different nested
nodes so
our the result of us being a symbolic
agent is that every time we meet someone
say you know who says they're Canadian
um well if we have met this person
before our model of what it means to be
Canadian now includes that person we now
have a you know instance of the con the
general concept of a Canadian of that
kind of General archetype so that means
that the model we have of Canadian
whether or not we are Canadian um
we have the ability to compute to
constantly compute what the self is um
and by virtue what the other is
and so this the kind of Road the tra the
trajectory that I outlin that kind of
brought us to here and what it means and
all that um I draw from our social bias
so what are kind of some instinctual

impulsive elements that first um started to see Human Society expand kind of outward laterally or even over time well at least laterally is kind of um within a specific time uh I make the case that it is social bias something that we are inherently born with um you know although we are not um you know born racist per se um we are born with a specific bias and that's accent bias or shth it does seem to be something that emerges in utero and we have preference for um pronunciations for vocal accents uh over others those we are more familiar with while that's all negative it does have clear biological benefits of course that's why it exists and that's why it you know persists today um and secondly what what do we do with a society that's based on people with the same accents um well that's an inherently un instable one when that's not um super adaptive AI is extensive and allows for greater cooperation um it's unstable because it allows for deviance free writing things like that okay so enter morality enter morals um and so here now we're connected in this um symbolic node Way by codifying those Expectations by minimizing surprise using morality right so this is my myth of objectivity um you're supposed to behave cooperatively you're supposed to follow these Norms by virtue of where you where you've grown up you know that is social bias that is

shth um evidently you are not doing that
so how do I deal with that surprise well
over time of course that model you have
um the shared model you have of um you
know that's based on identifying with
those like you starts to wear thin
starts to break down and so in comes
morality as a way to stabilize um
to offer kind of a hood that you place
on um deviants and that you can then you
know use to shame and guilt um into
aligning with the shared model um or of
course there's punishment ostracization
and other things right but that's what
the the tool that
morality probably had in the plene and
continues to have with us today all
right okay that third leg
is um okay so if this is itself self um
what are we modeling off of right so we
have the internal model Act of inference
we have the mark blanket that scream
between us and the world so then we have
the external States so what once we have
kind of symbolized itself what is the
world what exactly are we modeling off
of sometimes it's the world you can say
okay let think about um farming think
about you know someone who's born and
raised as a farmer the land will feature
very prominently in their model of the
world think about a hunter
land will figure um you know the world
itself the physical world will um you
know will mean something um however it
won't mean everything so what are some
other things that will constitute the
world probably the other right so social

bias of course Works into that there's those who sound like you there's those who's not or those not like you um so by virtue of having a bias means that you're biased away from other people and that's why we don't like to admit that we have biases um and that's why we were troubled when um people tell us that we're biased so that's one example over the trouble um with the other and you can think about you know the Cold War think about any time that you know a country is um you know under attack the other becomes prominent becomes Salient um the in group binds together and you know for a while um you whether it's 911 or whether it's World War II there's kind of great social cohesion trouble of Wars end um enemies become as Salient um and then what happens well this is you know how we have this is you know enter kind of Mythology not these things are entirely separable um there's a lot of overlap but um you know for our purposes if we think of you know mythology and we start to think of um narrative what we're talking about is uh in the language of Mel in fields we're explicating the reference frame we're explicating the measure the kind of yard stick of what's good what's bad um whether is you know according to Mike 11 the frame of reference that allows agents whether you know bacteria or complex organisms to judge whether they should approach something or they should

avoid it is it an internalized um
plane or frame of reference um what
we're doing eventually once we get to
myth once we get to um explicit morality
once we get to narrative is we're exola
that frame of reference we're saying
okay um you know these group of people
say are evil um you know we we're all
descended from this um ancestor you know
from you know Hercules from bolg from
this kind of half man half god um we
explicating these reference frames to
gain cultural solidarity decaying
cultural
cohesion right and so um I mentioned
this
uh this is more going into my um myth of
objectivity hypothesis but I'll just
kind of briefly show it because you know
I would love to get some feedback from
the folks listening to this um so this
is how I
have um I hope to formalize um you know
how we um you know
became symbolically literate um if you
will so that kind of passed from shith
to morals um to you know full symbolic
agent um and so I just have kind of an
agent here um assuming that another
Agent B has a fellow X and therefore
shares the model of the world has some
error you know the error reaches some
threshold um and then suddenly you know
if then else um you end up um with a new
model it eventually leads you
to um modeling the prediction error so
here have um a somewhat familiar
equation but kind of modified but

instead of

um uh taking the where the posterior is

kind of conditional on um traditionally

conditional on the model um here in

place of that I have you know an

objectified error um so the point is

that you have the these

categories of whereas you know typically

the prediction error will just be

whatever kind of noise that

you experience that are not in line with

the prediction um and other you'll

select a different prediction model um

different model at that point um or you

just assume it away as um as noise in

this case there is an explicit model of

error

so when someone decides to steal food

when someone decides to um not help with

uh childbearing when someone decides

um I can't think of any um moral

deviations um but um the point is that

there is a specific set

of deviations from the typical

predictions versus just being um

surprised generically so it's a modeled

version of error um that then allows uh

an agent a to view a given agent um as

possessing the ability to select between

adherence to a higher level or

superordinate model um now an objective

model um of the group or a narrow one so

they can comply or they can deviate

that's a C and D um subscript and the

point is that um or you know I guess one

one takeaway is that okay this is just

metacognition um that of upper level

superordinate G um and this is transc

meaning that it's not
um purely objective um it's framed as
objective from um the point of view of
the agent but that only means that
they're transcending
their own subjectivity and the
subjectivity of the agent um
by conceiving that they have the ability
to select
between a higher level or a lower level
model and so in this kind of simple way
at least at this level of explanation we
can see
how from an active inference point of
view we could have gotten to something
like objective morality uh and more
importantly something like Free
Will and of course the various different
significance and so just
um again a couple you know I view this
as um the kind
of a hypothesis hiding in plain sight
why because morality is something that
we're so impulsive about um something we
have so many emotional um ties to um you
know for instance
um we're constantly looking for vict um
we're constantly claiming to be the
victim we're constantly looking for um
people who
victimize um and yet we can't really
agree on what the specific contents of
morality should be even though as I'm
when I mentioned deontology I'm sure
there was folks
listening who had ideas of what could be
deontic meaning forever forever there um
so went over the some of this um you

know there's you know social biasing U
morality there's impulse to do this um
and there some kind of research that
I've done um in the economics going back
to that neoclassical Paradigm although
I was kind of dumping on it earlier um
what these single equilibrium analyses
allow for uh is the ability to say okay
where does this model break down where
does this model fall so you might say it
falls down everywhere
that's not quite true um people are uh
Salish they do have
um stationary preferences at least for
um a long enough time for that model to
be useful um however it does fall down
in certain interesting ways one
interesting failure of the single
equilibrium economics Paradigm is the
need for social trust um and so social
trust means that we have certain
expectations we have expectations that
company selling something sells what
they promise to sell um it means that
you can you know trust the market system
trust the institutions um in the market
that you inhabit and engage in economic
activity um so you think that this at
all levels you essentially need it
you essentially need to take medicine
and understand that hope the people are
um you know so ethically inclined um you
know because of course if um
they do something bad they might not get
caught for it yada the point is that
there needs to be some sort of um
agreement on social trust so it's an
example of how kind of morality seeps

its way into something even as
um even as intended to surgically remove
all kind of humanity from the Paradigm
all all morality all essence of morality
from econ um the study of Economics
social trust and morality seeps back
into it um the same thing with um
Linguistics um won't get into this one
too much now but the de of
transcendental signify so it's a way of
structuring otherwise of elusive um set
of symbols linguistic systems um we
always have something there's always as
I mentioned there's always God there's
always some sort of myth that's tying
everything together um even in secular
society we have not um you know we don't
have kind of uppercasse God G God the way
you might might have in the past you
know there's a lot of different
religions there's a lot of Institutions
and probably agnosticism and secularism
is kind of increasingly dominant um so
what do we have in this case we have
democracy we have um science we have
kind of other um essentially kind of
mantras if you will um that require this
kind of shared belief um element which
kind of has very moral characteristics
but is is kind of tied back into um a
kind of shared belief system um that
then Heathers our uh you know norms and
expectations too and allows for us um
they kind of have you know social and
political dialogue
um yeah um
I SP yeah I spent a bit of time on the
mythity hypothesis

um quickly um I don't know if I'll have
time for uh this entire run through um
but once we have established that
um we achieved a symbolic capacity um of
what is uh the next step do we just kind
of walk around shouting symbols um no we
have kind of narratives that uh attached
to our symbols it's the way we kind of
piece them together it's how we connect
one symbol to another at a very um kind
of crude way of describing this um
there's a recent paper on narrative
Theory active inference um which I
encourage um you know folks to go out
there and and um and seek um it covers
episodic memory it covers narrative
identity as so some interesting topics
throughout on narrative um the one thing
that I wanted to add is
um it makes the claim that narrative is
for the future it's for prediction just
as many things in um active inference
are however I think that you could
equally say that in order to
establish um you know a productive
prediction um we write narratives about
our past so we can separate you know the
person we were in high school um the
person we were um you know in our 20s
our 30s who we can we tell stories about
that about our last job in order to draw
a boundary between us um and that person
so it's a way of um of inheriting in in
um inhabiting various
selves um but not identifying not
overidentifying with the past one so I
just want to add that because I don't
think it was covered in the uh in that

paper um and so here I have a couple
different of the core elements of
narrative and why I think that it is SS
so well in the The Narrative Paradigm so
I think the story describes as a set of
you know the underlying events um so
it's

not explicitly what's in the narrative
so if we read a novel um and you know
the the novel is a short story
about um you know Harry Potter it's uh
exactly what's happening in that version
of Harry Potter maybe he's um you know
already at school doesn't kind of go
into to his backstory necessarily um um
but this but the the story is all the
things all the underlying events that
happen that are related that are
necessarily depicted in that narrative
um and so this is essentially the the
generative process right so it's the
outside world that's um you know that's
being modeled in um The Narrative and in
the kind of causal chain that is the
plot um so the point is that um uh kind
of kind of quick but the point is that
when discussing or when of
analyzing

um analytically the core elements of
narrative um you know a lot of the
themes that emerge are kind of similar
to um at least some of the key elements
of um active inference

yeah skip this one for now

um yeah so um one thing I think it's
important to notice is that there is
implicit versus kind of explicit
um narratives um and

so there's this there's the idea of of
feature placing um so this is
essentially how
um vocal vocalizations you know emerged
prior to symbolic CU so you know other
animals have
um verbal Expressions but they're non
symbolic um a feature placement
is um kind of one single
verbalization um that might be some way
that we can think about how
um language began um um and so
essentially the kind of going back okay
Concepts need context if we just s fire
um what does this mean does it mean that
I'm fired from a job does it mean that
something is burning um or does it mean
that you know I'm just um you know
someone said something go really cool
and I'm just saying fire uh in that kind
of slang
context um so exping the explicit so um
here uh I just wanted to raise um the
instance of
where creating narratives um although
everything can be narrated um not
everything um is
narrated um so there could be
unconscious events that happen in your
past or childhood or even during the day
that you haven't really thought about so
um various different therapeutic
techniques um address that so internal
failing systems is one where you address
um know different emotional states or
different um psychological States and
try to personify those and try to kind
of give them

um uh you know abstract structure in your mind by engaging with them you know through journaling or through uh dialogue with a therapist um so that's internal family systems there's also expressive writing similarly and so if we think about um one of the impacts that um narrative can have that that that's one and sometimes it's good to um you know not sometimes it's good or sometimes it's just um a fact that we don't have narratives like we don't have narratives on all of our feelings every day I don't think we would be able to narrate everything that's that's happening to us um if we think about meditation and mantras the ideas there is that you know for a time at least we shouldn't narrate everything or at least we shouldn't accept the first kind of order narration um which we think about mindful minut medit and kind of focusing on their breath as opposed to following our thoughts um you know if for anyone who practice meditation you know you'll know that um sometimes we should just you know be quiet and not listen um to the narratives that that show up in our brain have a couple different obviously examples

um right so here what I'm talking about is and as I mentioned on the previous slide or I had it written down I don't know if I um spoke to it um but we're talking about here is that the problem of in promise of cultural narratives this is most known as Master narrative or grand narratives um

that traditionally would have been
the purview of Mythology and religion on
more modern times
um is kind of constructed um in other
ways and so um as I
mentioned from our nomadic multiband
past um to even agrarian societ
um and then kind of coming into the
universal
age these um started from these fully
integrated narratives where a particular
nomadic um HRA tribe would have a single
kind of Master cultural narrative um or
at least that's what we understand as
our kind of best guess is that this was
the case or wasn't um you know which
religion do my part of I'm part of my
tribe's religion um you know why did uh
we catch food today and and and not
yesterday there was you know an answer
from the shaman for that you this this
it was fully integrated um the second
kind of epoch was the leading up to kind
of the the axial age when the
universalizing religion you know the
stage for Christianity um you know
Hinduism um you know Daoism that that I
mentioned um so for a very long time um
this is kind of following from you know
10,000 years ago when we um started
farming um perhaps up until recently we
had these dominant religions um that
essentially kind of took over the the
sphere um those are the the universal
narratives religious Nares I'm sure
folks are aware of and most recently in
um weird Societies or Western societies
is kind of Western educated

industrialized rich and Democratic um
that's the acronym for for weird there
um and my case here is that these are
you know we're largely in a culturally
fragmented environment
so earlier when I mentioned single
equilibrium analysis neoclassical
economics but specifically um
deontology um and utilitarianism those
are all examples of from I think a
thermodynamic systems point of view from
an active inference point of view this
would be kind of a um a very um single
equilibrium um you know kind of ways of
looking at the world
um and why are they well um you know
according to Joseph Enrique and I think
According to some similar analysis from
um Ian M
Christs um this is because Western
people are distinctly individualistic um
they're a bit more left brain um
centered than um at least the axial age
portion of um Society so those um
traditionally of settled societies um
that are more just salt and more red
brain oriented
um would think of things a bit more
holistically uh rather than as kind of
reductive so the good of course there's
um you know many benefits for left brain
thinking it's um more individual it's
more analytical uh and it'll be a bit
more geared towards science um versus
mythology versus um stories and
narrative um but what is it missing well
it can make a lot of
um mistakes and not kind of random

mistakes um a specific type of uh
mistake which is um leads to kind of
reductionism um and which is how we kind
of ended up with which might be
according to these views how we kind of
ended up with um some of the paradigms
that we did
yeah and so the the fragmentation we can
understand along kind of three different
these three different dimensions right
so one is aesthetic uh the next is kind
of institutional and the final the last
is uh kind of objective and so um this
is essentially how I see our Master
narrative currently broken down um and
of course there could be additional ways
but here's one of three ways as a
starting point point to understand the
kind of cultural narrative
um and how specifically it's it's
fragmented so aesthetic we have the kind
of modern era the postmodern era and um
now what some people are calling the
better modern era it's maybe a bit too
soon to um turn on it however I do think
it's super interesting especially in the
light of the free engine principle um
which I'll hopefully have time at the
end to kind of um touch on um the second
one is our institutional um
so uh the economic framework um you know
how we should distribute wealth
um you know what does that say about us
and kind of what's the most quote
unquote efficient way um but what are
the narratives around um our economics
what's our narratives around our
politics um and finally there there's

this idea of uh of you know objectivity
still kind of creeping in so um what are
the kind of true narratives out
there um

and

so you know a reasonable question is
okay this is you know we all have kind
of our own stories um perhaps there's
still vague senses of a master narrative
and I think you know there're always um
are uh there always kind of might be
um at least some emergent

um Master

narratives by virtue of us kind of all
occupying the same at least you know
digital space the same kind of time um
will all Converge on some things um
however without

a um kind of

coherent or

a more of like a religious story that we
um perspective that you know we had in
the past where um you the narrative is
not just um okay we're this you know
Third Rock From the Sun we're revolving
around um we wol around space and you
know we're a victim to to laws and um
this is what happens to be happening
with Society um what we lose with the
kind of grand Cosmic narratives of the
past um the type of psychological um
coherence um so where do we fit into
this world you know the idea of going
back to kind of cosmic ban you know
where is our place in the universe um
what is that kind of personal meaning
for me that's where a
um a tighter narrative kind of more

intentional Master narrative um comes
into play so our current fragmentation
um leads to personal anxiety it can lead
to social anxiety um and it can lead to
kind of the polarization uh and
partisanship and the results are
fragmentation institutional misalignment
so
whether the company you're working for
um shares your value
use um whether they're working on
something that is you find deeply
meaningful that is deeply meaningful for
your identity um and your values um
that's um what you mean thereby
misalignment and so in terms of
Aesthetics um as I mentioned um the per
is is sometimes called metamodernism um
and so that kind of gets
into the idea of genres meaning that we
have kind of plenty of good um you know
television should be have plenty of good
narratives available um for us to
consume um that does include um kind of
classic genres um but the problem is
that they're all genres so we're all
kind of consuming different
um content we're all consuming it
through different media um even in times
past um not even too far past uh we
would watch TV at the same time
you watch the same movies because
because they're in the movie theater
that's where you could that's the only
place you could watch them um up until
recently um now we're watching movies at
different times moving from movies from
um 20 30 years back um from 50 years

back and the essentially the
fragmentation um has gone up an
explanation
as I mentioned there there's an
analytical um orientation um and so
here um I think it's it's worth noting
that along with the fragmentation that
has occurred in weird societies um along
kind of side that that kind of
loneliness that happens um with the rise
of uh the analytical world is some great
some great
literature um and so one of the reasons
I argue that
this came about was specifically because
um once theology once
religion
stopped serving the role that it did um
that left in particular artists in
particular those kind of aesthetically
inclined to seek out um art and to
create art in some cases to fill those
gaps for
um offering a narrative for answering
the questions the big questions that
were typically answered by those
institutions um and
so kind of going back
to my quest what we're kind of after
here is we're looking for greater um
cultural cohesion we're aiming for
better personal and social integration
so I argue that these pieces are
connected um and I'd argue that
if the free if the free principle has
told us one thing um it that agents
minimiz uncertainty however if it tells
us another thing is that one way to

verify kind of any Claim about um the
self-organizing system it's to not look
at one Paradigm assignments to look at
it's to synthesize various different
views so what we can glean from that is
essentially a meta modern approach
um which is to not
necessarily ensure that everyone in
culture everyone in a particular society
is consuming the same content or media
but it's to highlight certain aspects of
it that each person can find
meaning and the right type of meaning in
their own
content and even if we
achieve that through different areas
will'll all be experiencing something
similar with each of our Traditions
or and once we've identified the certain
components or make the case for certain
components um
that answer maybe some important
questions from active impers point of
view and
allow greater visibility
into that uncertainty minimizing process
at a cultural
scale um so here I think poetry is a
great
example because of it um you know it
reaches everything from the senses from
its sounds to its visuals
um to its know deal deeper symbolic
meaning and I think know great great
example of that is TS Elliott um the
great many
references he makes in his work um and
also um the kind of

poetic conventions he adheres to makes it

just become

very uh in some cases accessible

um works that he offers and so whether

it's TS Elliot or Kendrick Lamar um

in each case what these

artists

constructing is a ex symbolic self and

explicated um a number of different

nodes in a hierarchy um that are

connected with all these various

references in a particular song

um that are that can be made clear you

know for instance in uh

um this it's genius so you can see where

the different um lines in this case

Kendrick Lamar has and what the references

were and so in a sense what you

experience when we read poetry or we

read a work of fiction that has um deep

references deep um cultural references

like this it's constructing an extensive

self um bringing coherence to it and to

everyone who listens to it um and by

kind of calling it out you're able

to share in it almost as if you know

it's something you know it's a greater

work of literature in the past um as

folks would and so that I think is of

a few examples of

um ways we

can start to apply a rigorous framework

to the humanities to tell what kind of

literature does for us why it does what

it does for us um and and parse through

some of the components

that make it

meaningful to us and kind of allow us to

um use literature um in ways that I
think it was originally intended to in
past times
has so leave it there and um you know
once again feel free
to um reach out to me with my contact
information and
um and please you know follow my um you
know substack and and let me know if um
anyone has any feedback and I just want
to thank Daniel Freedman again um and
you know all the folks at active
inference Institute and Carl priston for
um the this content and um the
discussions here so uh thanks
again e